

REVIEW

Do school smartphone bans improve grades and mental health?

REFERENCES	STYLE	MADE WITH	VERIFICATION	COMPILED
10 verified	Bullets	Grounded v0.5.5	Crossref · claims	5 Sep 2026

SUMMARY

School phone restrictions may improve some academic or emotional outcomes, but reliable gains in grades or mental health remain uncertain. Confidence is low because studies compare different restrictions, measure different outcomes, and largely cannot isolate policy effects from other school differences.

01 Phone access and student outcomes are separate tests

>> In a laboratory task, undergraduates recalled more accurately when phones were kept out of sight.¹ This supports a distraction mechanism, but does not test school grades or lasting mental-health effects.¹ A review likewise found mostly negative associations between general smartphone use and academic performance, without establishing causality.²

>> The school-policy question is whether changing access improves student outcomes. [Figure 1](#) separates an access rule from the assessment of benefit.

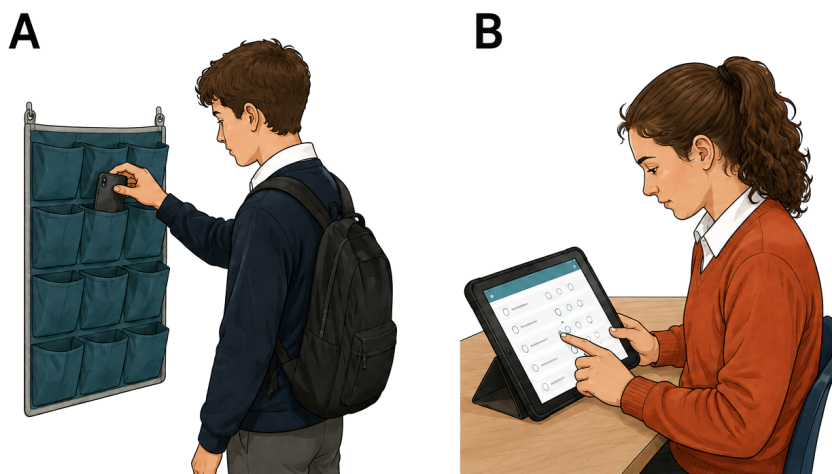


Figure 1. An access rule is distinct from an outcome assessment. Panel A illustrates phone storage; panel B illustrates questionnaire-based assessment. The scenes represent neither treatment groups nor an effect size. These policy evaluations compared different restrictions and measured student outcomes separately.^{3,4}

02 Less school-time use without a detected wellbeing advantage

>> In the English SMART Schools comparison, most permissive schools allowed phones during breaks or in designated zones.³ Pupils in restrictive schools reported less school-time use: an adjusted difference of -0.67 hours daily, with a 95% [confidence interval](#) from -0.92 to -0.43 .³ Overall weekday and weekend use showed no detectable policy-group difference.³

>> The same comparison found no evidence of better mental wellbeing, with uncertainty spanning benefit and harm ([Figure 2](#)).³ Unmeasured school differences and possible under-reporting of use in restrictive schools limit what these [cross-sectional findings](#) establish about policy effects.³

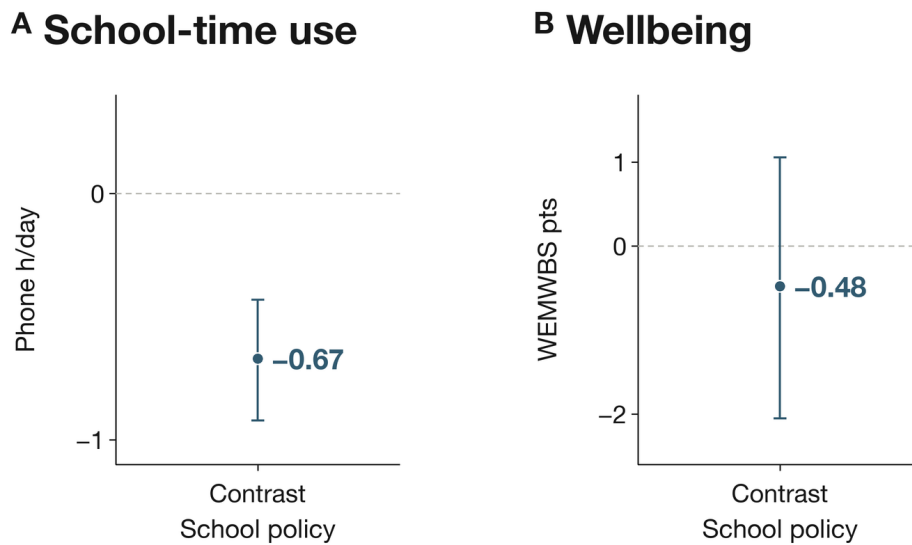


Figure 2. Lower school-time use did not establish better wellbeing. Both panels report the restrictive-minus-permissive school comparison. Vertical axes show adjusted differences in phone hours per school day (A) and Warwick–Edinburgh Mental Wellbeing Scale points (B). Panel A is -0.67 hours, with a 95% confidence interval of -0.92 to -0.43 .³ Points mark estimates, whiskers mark intervals, and dashed zero lines mark no difference; the panels use different units. Panel B is -0.48 points, with a 95% confidence interval of -2.05 to 1.06 ; the observational comparison does not establish causality.³

03 Academic gains and engagement answer different questions

- » A Spanish regional comparison found test-score gains after bans in Galicia; the authors expressed the maths gains as 0.6–0.8 years of learning.⁵ Its comparison of regional changes before and after implementation supports a setting-specific finding rather than a uniform effect across schools.⁵
- » A South Australian evaluation instead measured self-reported academic engagement over one month.⁴ Earlier versus newly introduced bans showed no detectable follow-up advantage: a standardized difference of 0.03, with a 95% confidence interval of -0.14 to 0.20 .⁴ Both groups had bans by follow-up, and registration occurred after data collection; this does not settle the effect of bans versus no bans on examination performance.⁴
- » A rapid review pooled a small benefit across academic and social outcomes from five studies, while describing the academic evidence as limited.⁶ That combined estimate cannot resolve the difference between improved test scores and no detected follow-up advantage in engagement.

04 Emotional outcomes remain mixed

- » An Australian secondary analysis of a natural experiment associated already implemented bans with small reductions in psychological distress, while reporting no significant improvement in positive mood.⁷ Its observational design leaves the causal effect uncertain.⁷

- » A Dutch comparison tested the added restriction of a full ban over a classroom-only ban and found no detectable wellbeing or bullying advantage.⁸ With no unrestricted comparator and a cross-sectional design, it cannot establish a general ban effect.⁸
- » The Hungarian study measured a more immediate response: anxiety rose during a mobile-free day.⁹ The single-school comparison lacked a separate control school and had substantial dropout, limiting conclusions about permanent policies.⁹
- » Qualitative SMART Schools accounts described benefits and drawbacks under both policy types; these experiences cannot establish an effect size.¹⁰ Across the comparisons, possible benefits remain compatible with low confidence in a dependable improvement in grades or mental health.

Scope and methods — Narrative review rebuilt from OpenAlex and PubMed searches dated 4 September 2026, including recent and contrary findings; no new literature search was conducted. Peer-reviewed school-policy comparisons informed conclusions, with laboratory and general-use studies supplying context. Five cited papers were read in full and five through abstracts. Australian analyses and SMART Schools publications were grouped by study family; review overlap was not treated as independent replication. Crossref screening found no integrity signal on the search date.



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